

**UNIT
3**

**ACTIVE AND
PASSIVE VOICE**

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Tense	Active Voice Structure	Passive Voice Structure	Example Active	Example Passive
Present Simple	Subject + base verb (s/es) + Object	Subject + is/are + past participle	She writes a letter.	A letter is written by her.
Present Continuous	Subject + is/are + verb-ing	Subject + is/are + being + past participle	They are playing football.	Football is being played by them.
Present Perfect	Subject + has/have + past participle	Subject + has/have + been + past participle	He has finished his homework.	His homework has been finished by him.
Past Simple	Subject + past verb	Subject + was/were + past participle	She made a cake.	A cake was made by her.
Past Continuous	Subject + was/were + verb-ing	Subject + was/were + being + past participle	I was reading a book.	A book was being read by me.
Past Perfect	Subject + had + past participle	Subject + had + been + past participle	They had completed the task.	The task had been completed by them.
Future Simple	Subject + will + base verb	Subject + will + be + past participle	He will write a letter.	A letter will be written by him.
Future Perfect	Subject + will + have + past participle	Subject + will + have + been + past participle	He will have completed the work.	The work will have been completed by him.

In active voice, the subject of the sentence performs the action. In passive voice, the subject of the sentence receives the action. We form the passive with the verb to be and the past participle of the main verb.

When Do We Use the Passive Voice?

We use the passive voice in the following situations:

1. When the agent (the person who does the action) is unknown, unimportant, or obvious from the context.

- **Example:** The door had been locked. (We don't know who locked it – unknown agent.)
- **Example:** Repairs are being made to the car. (By the mechanic – obvious agent.)

2. When we are more interested in the action than the person who carries it out.

- Often used in news reports, formal notices, instructions, processes, headlines, advertisements, etc.
- **Example:** The whole area was evacuated. (News report.)
- **Example:** Breakfast is served from 6:00 to 10:30. (Formal notice.)

Changing from Active to Passive

When converting active voice into passive voice, the object of the sentence becomes the subject of the passive sentence. The doer (agent) may or may not be mentioned, depending on its importance.

Example:

- **Active:** The mayor opened the new school.
Subject Verb Object
- **Passive:** The new school was opened by the mayor.
Subject Verb Agent

Key Rules for Passive Voice

1. Only transitive verbs can be changed into the passive.

Example (transitive): Sami feeds the dogs.

- **Passive:** The dogs are fed by Sami.

Example (intransitive): They sleep early every night.

- ("Sleep" is intransitive; no object, so no passive form.)

2. Some transitive verbs cannot be changed into passive.

Example: have, fit, suit, resemble.

- **Active:** She resembles her father in many ways.
(Cannot be made passive.)

3. By + agent vs. With + instrument/material/ingredient.

We use **by + agent** to say who or what carries out the action.

Use "by" for the doer of the action.

- **Example:** The cake was made by Ann.
Use "with" for the instrument, material, or ingredient used.
- **Example:** It was made with eggs, flour, and butter.

4. Verbs with two objects. (Direct and indirect objects)

Direct object is the object that gets affected by the action of the verb.

Note: If the direct object comes soon after the verb, it doesn't take any preposition.

eg) I give you a pen. (no preposition after the verb)

eg) I bake you a cake. (no preposition after the verb)

Indirect object: is the object that takes the benefit of the action.

Note: If the indirect object comes soon after the direct object, no preposition comes in between, but if the indirect object comes soon after the verb, it follows either "to" or "for" before the direct object.

eg) I give a pen to you. (to as preposition comes before the direct object)

eg) I bake a cake for you. (for as preposition comes before the direct object)

With verbs which take two objects such as bring, **allow, award, bring, buy, feed, give, grant, hand, lend, offer, owe, pass, post, promise, read, send, show, take, tell, throw and write**, it is more usual to begin the passive sentence with the person. We can make two different passive sentences.

Verb: Send

1. Active (Double Objects): She **sent** me a letter.

Passive (Direct Object): A letter **was sent** to me by her.

Passive (Indirect Object): I **was sent** a letter by her.

2. Active (Preposition): She **sent** a letter to me.

Passive (Direct Object): A letter **was sent** to me by her.

Passive (Indirect Object): I **was sent** a letter by her.

Verb: Show

1. Active (Double Object): He **showed** them his project.

Passive (Direct Object): His project **was shown** to them by him.

Passive (Indirect Object): They **were shown** his project by him.

2. Active (Preposition): He **showed** his project to them.

Passive (Direct Object): His project **was shown** to them by him.

Passive (Indirect Object): They **were shown** his project by him.

Verb: Tell

1. Active (Double Object): She **told** us a story.

Passive (Direct Object): A story **was told** to us by her.

Passive (Indirect Object): We **were told** a story by her.

2. Active (Preposition): She **told** a story to us.

Passive (Direct Object): A story **was told** to us by her.

Passive (Indirect Object): We **were told** a story by her.

Verb: Offer

1. Active (Double Object): He **offered** her a job.

Passive (Direct Object): A job **was offered** to her by him.

Passive (Indirect Object): She **was offered** a job by him.

2. Active (Preposition): He offered a job to her.

Passive (Direct Object): A job **was offered** to her by him.

Passive (Indirect Object): She **was offered** a job by him.

Verb: Lend

1. Active (Double Object): She **lent** me her notebook.

Passive (Direct Object): Her notebook **was lent** to me by her.

Passive (Indirect Object): I **was lent** her notebook by her.

2. Active (Preposition): She **lent** her notebook to me.

Passive (Direct Object): Her notebook **was lent** to me by her.

Passive (Indirect Object): I **was lent** her notebook by her.

5. Agent omission.

- Omit "by + agent" when the agent is unknown, unimportant, or obvious from the context:
 - **Active:** They painted the house.
 - **Passive:** The house was painted. ("by them" is omitted.)

6. Infinitive usage in active and passive.

Verbs like make, see, help, and hear use an infinitive without "to" in active voice but with "to" in passive voice:

Active: They helped him tidy the garage.

Passive: He was helped to tidy the garage.

7. Reporting Passives

Reporting passives are sentences that use the **passive voice** to report what someone has said, thought, or believed. They are commonly used in formal writing to focus on the information rather than the person who gave it.

Structure:

- **It is said/known/believed/claimed** + that + clause
- Subject + **is/was said/known/believed/claimed** + to + verb

Examples:

1. Active: People say that she is a great teacher.

Passive: It is said that she is a great teacher.

Passive (alternative): She is said to be a great teacher.

2. Active: Scientists believe that climate change is caused by humans.

Passive: It is believed that climate change is caused by humans.

Passive (alternative): Climate change is believed to be caused by humans.

Why Use Reporting Passives?

- To make the statement sound more formal or objective.
- To shift the focus from the speaker to the information being reported.

8. Passive after modal verbs.

- Use "be + past participle" or "have been + past participle" after modal verbs:
 - **Active:** He can't repair the lock.
 - **Passive:** The lock can't be repaired.
 - **Active:** They may have painted the house.
 - **Passive:** The house may have been painted.

9. Verbs followed by prepositions.

The preposition remains directly after the verb in the passive voice:

Active: They accused him of murder.

Passive: He was accused of murder.

10. Passive questions.

- Use "by" in questions starting with who/whom/which:
 - **Active:** Who gave you this book?
 - **Passive:** By whom were you given this book?
OR Who were you given this book by?

Note: Use "By whom were you given this book?" for formal contexts and "Who were you given this book by?" for casual speech.

11. Participles as adjectives and past participles.

- Participles like **amazed, broken, interested, pleased**, etc., can function as adjectives or past participles:
 - **Adjective:** The first time I saw the building, I was amazed. ("amazed" as an adjective.)
 - **Past Participle:** I was amazed by your work. ("amazed" as a past participle.)

EXERCISES

Exercise: 1

Rewrite the sentences in the passive voice if possible.

1. They paint the house beautifully.

2. She doesn't clean the office every evening at 5:00.

3. Do volunteers plant trees in the forest?

4. They closed the road due to an oil spill.

5. He didn't send the party invitations yesterday afternoon.

6. Did they discover America in 1492?

7. They will award him a Nobel prize.

8. He will not play tennis.

9. Will he offer a good deal on pizza?

10. They are organizing a cultural event.

11. She isn't fixing the car.

12. Are they preparing the dinner?

13. The children were solving a puzzle.

14. The workers weren't repairing the bridge.

15. Were they conducting an experiment?

16. She has signed the contract.

17. He hasn't cleaned the kitchen yet.

18. Have they completed the assignment?

19. The author had written a novel before the deadline.

20. The chef hadn't prepared the dessert.

21. Had they visited the museum?

22. They can repair the roof.

23. She shouldn't open the door.

24. Will they finish the work by tomorrow?

25. They gave her a medal.

26. They didn't show him the report.

27. Did she offer them any help?

28. She swims in the pool.

29. They didn't sleep well last night.

30. Did the baby cry loudly?

31. Has she watered the plants?

32. They saw a dolphin swimming in the sea.

33. You should handle this package carefully.

34. They include tax in the bill.

Exercise: 2

Put the verbs in brackets into the correct passive tense.

1. A: When is breakfast served? (breakfast/serve)?

B: From 7:00 to 10:00 in the morning.

2. A: I think this is the best bakery in town.

B: I agree. Fresh bread _____ (bake) here every morning.

3. A: Can I eat my sandwich here?

B: Certainly not, sir. Food _____ (not/allow) in the

library.

4. A: There are not enough bins on our streets.

B: I know. Something _____ (should/do) about this problem.

5. A: When _____ (rubbish/collect)?

B: On Mondays and Thursdays.

6. A: Who _____ (the light bulb/invent) by?

B: Thomas Edison.

7. A: Did you hear that the airport is closed because of the snow?

B: Yes. It _____ (announce) on the radio this morning.

8. A: This is a really busy museum.

B: Yes. It _____ (visit) by over 1,000 people every day.

9. A: Are you going to Sarah's birthday party tonight?

B: No, I _____ (not/invite).

10. A: Did you hear that the jeweller's _____ (break into) yesterday?

B: Yes, I heard. But the thief _____ (catch) soon afterwards.

11. A: Who _____ (the race/win) by?

B: Sami. He's an excellent athlete.

12. A: The Lahore Fort is an amazing historic site.

B: I know. Royal gatherings and ceremonies _____
(hold) there hundreds of years ago.

Exercise: 3

Fill in by or with.

1. Most children are strongly influenced by their parents.
2. The jam sandwiches are made _____ white bread.
3. Sarah was dismissed _____ her boss.
4. The parcels are tied _____ string.
5. The meal is eaten _____ chopsticks.
6. The show was presented _____ Ted Jones.
7. The basket is filled _____ fresh bread.
8. The dishes were prepared _____ a top chef.
9. The phone was answered _____ his colleague.
10. The room is decorated _____ flowers.
11. The song was performed _____ Rihanna.
12. This awful mess was made _____ Ali's cat.
13. My hair was cut _____ a top stylist.
14. The goal was scored _____ Liverpool's youngest player.
15. The beds are made up _____ clean sheets.
16. The shop was robbed _____ a masked man.
17. Ali was congratulated _____ a friend.
18. The cups were filled _____ hot tea.
19. The building was designed _____ a Pakistani architect.
20. Their bread is made _____ brown flour.

Exercise: 4

Rewrite the newspaper headlines as complete sentences.



1. *A child was rescued from fire yesterday.*

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

Exercise: 5

Identify the word in bold as an adjective or past participle.

1. The audience were **amused** by the play.

past participle

2. The last time I went to the dentist, I was **scared**.

3. She was **worried** all day after hearing the news.

4. The students were **bored** by the lecturer's long speech.

5. She was **exhausted** after cleaning the house all day.

6. Sarah was **delighted** with all her birthday presents.

Exercise: 6

Complete the sentences, as in the example.

1. It is expected that she will pass the test easily.

She is expected to pass the test easily.

2. It is said that the children were the cause of the damage.

The children _____

3. He is considered to be the best football player in the country.

It _____

4. They believe that he attended the wedding.

He _____

5. The news presenter reported that the criminal has escaped.

The criminal _____

6. People think that he stole the paintings.

He _____

7. He is said to have lived in France last year.

It _____

8. The company is thought to be losing a lot of money.

It _____